Movie Maverick: 100 Years of Roger Corman

The Masque of the Red Death

The Masque of the Red Death
Directed by: Roger Corman
©: Alta Vista Productions
Presented by: James H. Nicholson, Samuel Z. Arkoff
Assistant Director: Peter Price
Continuity: Joan Davis
Casting Director: G.B. Walker
Screenplay by: Charles Beaumont, R. Wright Campbell
From a story by: Edgar Allan Poe
Photographed by: Nicolas Roeg
Camera Operator: Alex Thomson
Special Effects: George Blackwell
Film Editor: Ann Chegwidden
Art Direction by: Robert Jones
Set Dresser: Colin Southcott
Costume Supervisor: Laura Nightingale
Make-up: George Partleton
Hairdresser: Elsie Alder
Titles Designed by: Jim Baker
Music by: David Lee
Choreography by: Jack Carter
Sound: Richard Bird, Len Abbott
Dubbing Editor: Allan Morrison
Sound System: RCA Sound Recording

US prints
an American International *picture*
Produced by: Roger Corman
Production Design by: Daniel Haller
US press materials: Associate Producer: George Willoughby; *Filmed in:* Pathecolor

UK prints
an Anglo Amalgamated *picture*
Produced by: George Willoughby
Filmed at the: Elstree Studios of Associated British Picture Corporation
UK press materials: Print by: Technicolor
uncredited
Production Secretary: Valerie Kent
2nd Assistant Director: Bernard Williams
3rd Assistant Director: Michael Gowans
Focus Pullers: Kevin Kavanagh, Gordon Hayman
Clapper Loader: Tom Naylor
Stills Photography: George Higgins
Assistant Editor: Ernie Grimsdale
2nd Assistant Editor: Lorna Armour
Draughtsman: Edwin Galligan
Scenic Artist: Bill Beavis
Construction Manager: Richard Frift
Boom Operator: Don Wortham
Publicity: Edna Tromans

Cast:
Vincent Price *(Prince Prospero)*
Hazel Court *(Juliana)*
Jane Asher *(Francesca)*
David Weston *(Gino)*
Nigel Green *(Ludovico)*
Patrick Magee *(Alfredo)*
Paul Whitsun-Jones *(Scarlatti)*
Robert Brown *(guard)*
Julian Burton *(Senor Veronese)*
David Davies *(lead villager)*
Skip Martin *(Hop Toad)*
Gaye Brown *(Senora Escobar)*
Verina Greenlaw *(Esmeralda)*
Doreen Dawne *(Anna-Marie)*
Brian Hewlett *(Lampridi)*
Sarah Brackett *(grandmother)*

UK prints
Rosemarie Dunham
Jean Lodge *(Scarlatti's wife)*

SPOILER WARNING The following notes give away some of the plot.

The Masque of the Red Death, Roger Corman's first British film, shared a double bill with *X-Ray Eyes* and conclusively silenced any doubts about Corman being little more than a clever and opportunistic craftsman. Another Poe adaptation, it continues to flout Poe's spirit but this time puts back something powerful, basically serious and almost visionary in its own right. The shafts of irreverent humour remain, but on this occasion they spring from the satanism of Vincent Price's uncommonly forceful Prince Prospero. Once described as a 'sissified Bela Lugosi', Price here presents evil intellectually, the relish tempered with cool disquisitions upon the nature of fear, the domination over others effortless and indisputable, the moments of frenzy stylised and arresting. Indeed it is Price alone who makes the weakest scene, the Masque itself, work. As the Red Death stalks through the crowded ballroom, condemning the guests to nothing more alarming than a spraygun of letterbox paint, one is held by the sight of Price in his sheikish fancy dress, pursuing and then fleeing the intruder. While the revellers contort themselves in balletic poses, Price relies upon hieratic gestures, arms cumbrously upraised and features pained.

Apart from the actual Masque, there is very little sign of Corman's old penchant for gaudy, filtered colour effects and unsubtle trickwork. In fact the film is strikingly handsome, with vast, impressive sets, fluid camerawork and majestically tasteful colour. Moreover none of this is the work of Corman's usual collaborators, but of British technicians (notably the photographer Nicolas Roeg) who have succeeded in making a refreshingly un-British (or at any rate non-Hammer) British horror movie, with shock cuts that really shock and a leisurely-paced air of genuine contemplation.

Corman's debts are those of the enthusiastic cinephile. That's to say the piece is emblazoned with grateful bows to other films and directors: to *The Seventh Seal* for the configuration of Death and the poetic last scene – the gathering of the plague-bringers and the listing of the survivors; to Basil Rathbone's inhumanly reckless coach-driving (*A Tale of Two Cities*) for the first sight of Price in his carriage ('Burn the village to the ground'); to Bergman again and Buñuel for the scenes of humiliation and destruction – the grovelling guests displaying their various animal natures, the revenge of the dwarf upon Patrick Magee's aristocrat, disguised as an ape and then hoisted in flames upon a candelabra. These references to other films nowhere detract from Corman's own achievement. They are fully assimilated into a personal concept that is at once brutish and unsensational, evil-clouded yet illuminated with tenderness (the two dwarfs, the village child, Prospero's unwilling, puzzled respect for his young prisoner, Francesca), sophisticated yet simple as a legend.

The performances are on a higher level than in Corman's previous films. Skip Martin's gilded, whip-cracking dwarf, Patrick Magee's sly ape-aristocrat, John Westbrook's sonorous and faceless Red Death, are all excellent. A much-improved Hazel Court tackles the tricky business of marrying the Devil and being clawed to death by a falcon with aplomb. And if Jane Asher is a bit squeaky as innocent Francesca, she's still an improvement on some of Corman's Hollywood juveniles.

Peter John Dyer, *Sight and Sound*, Autumn 1964

John Stone *(guard)*
Harvey Hall *(Clistor)*
Gladys Dawson *(old crone)*

UK press materials
John Westbrook *('Red Death')*

USA-UK 1964©
86 mins
Digital 4K (restoration)

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The first thing that strikes one about *The Masque of the Red Death* is that, apart from a rather scruffy opening sequence, it looks quite stunningly handsome. An interview in *Positif* suggests that Corman's favourite art director, Daniel Haller, worked uncredited on the film [on British prints], but there is no sign of the hazy, filtered colour effects which tactfully conceal decorative limitations in the American Poe films. Here the colour is brilliantly sharp and clear, and Corman is just the man to make the most of the solid and exquisitely wrought sets and costumes permitted by a comparatively high budget, whether introducing the lovely mosaic flooring of Prospero's castle in a reflective overhead shot as Vincent Price paces slowly across it, or dazzling the eye with sudden changes from white to yellow, purple and black by tracking Jane Asher as she wings through a series of four adjoining rooms, each designed in a different colour motif. The compositions are excellent throughout, and certain scenes – the frightened girl outlined against a fluttering gauze curtain, or the two dwarfs and their huge Borzoi dog lost in the lavish expanses of the ballroom – are reminiscent of Riccardo Freda at his best.

Unlike *The Spectre* or *The Terror of Dr. Hichcock*, however, *The Masque of the Red Death* is graced by an uncommonly intelligent script which probes the concept of diabolism with considerable subtlety. Where most films of this nature tend simply to pile on the blood, here there is a genuine chill of intellectual evil, because Vincent Price, initiating horrible tortures with a characteristic air of sadistic glee, also conveys a genuine philosophical curiosity as to the unknown territories into which his quest for evil may lead him. One readily believes in this world of Prospero's, where good and evil are not merely empty words, but ideas to be tested and perhaps found wanting. And Corman's detail is brilliantly unsettling: Prospero illustrates the naturalness of violent death by demonstrating a falcon at work, and it is this same falcon which later tears Juliana to pieces; the pretty little Esmeralda speaks with an alluring (dubbed) voice sharply at odds with her Dresden doll appearance; Hop Toad (a splendid performance by Skip Martin), so gentle in his love for Esmeralda, devises the most fiendish death for Alfredo; and Prospero himself remains curiously ambiguous, evil certainly, but strangely tender in his dealings with Francesca, so that when he spares the village child, it is almost as if he had been touched by grace from Francesca.

At times, in fact, the film reminds one of *The Seventh Seal* in its intellectual probings, in its figuration of Death, and, particularly, in the conception of the final sequence. After the great Masque (the film's one real disappointment – the choreography is strictly conventional), one sits back to await the statutory scene reuniting the lovers after their adventures, only to discover with a shock of pleasure that Corman instead does the unexpected and rejoins Bergman for a scene in which the emissaries of Death gather to report on the plague's devastations through the world. In the naming of the survivors, five of whom we know, the sixth being a strange, unidentified old man, is a touch of that imagination which breeds poetry.

Tom Milne, *Monthly Film Bulletin*, August 1964